



Diversifying focus: IPL money is going global, with franchises investing across leagues worldwide. But when one sport already dominates India's economy, should more of that wealth be reinvested at home? PTI

Imagine a Bengaluru sporting institution operating cricket, football, women's cricket, volleyball and academies under one umbrella. Imagine Kolkata reviving its historic club culture into a modern multi-sport platform. Imagine Chennai, Ahmedabad or Lucknow building year-round city brands rather than seasonal, cricket-centric assets.

Sponsors would buy into annual ecosystems. Fans would engage for 12 months. Academies would become both a pipeline and a business, while merchandise, memberships and content would generate recurring revenue.

This future is not theoretical. JSW already owns teams across cricket, football and kabaddi while investing in Olympic sports. Reliance has built beyond teams into pathways and infrastructure. RPSG spans cricket and football. But many such investments remain scattered rather than rooted in one geography.

Seven IPL franchise owners have already expanded overseas, buying teams in South Africa, the UAE, the Caribbean and elsewhere.

Profits generated in India are being exported to acquire cricketing assets abroad. But when one sport already commands more than 80 per cent of the domestic sports economy, there is a legitimate question: should some of that capital instead be reinvested into the underfunded Indian sports ecosystem? Should governments remain passive, or design smart incentives through tax rebates, infrastructure credits, co-investment schemes and grassroots grants as cross-sport ownership benefits for franchise groups that invest meaningfully in city-based multi-sport development?

The opportunity now is to build across sports within India: an RCB football team in Bengaluru, a CSK women's cricket team in Chennai, an LSG hockey team in Lucknow, a Gujarat Titans volleyball team in Ahmedabad, all tied to a city crest.

To make these teams not just tenants of the city, but part of its psyche and consciousness.

The next phase of Indian sport should not be global acquisition but local permanence. Franchises must become sporting institutions embedded in the heartbeat of their cities.